

The orchestra

A favorite large ensemble for classical music, orchestras provide a flexible, richly varied, and colorful palette of sounds and textures for a composer to work with.

Orchestra

Large orchestras of 50 or more players are called “symphony” orchestras, while smaller ensembles are known as “chamber” orchestras. Symphony orchestras have the full range of woodwind, brass, and percussion, and also a large number of orchestral strings—first and second violins, violas, cellos, and double basses. There may be one or more harps, and sometimes even a piano or an organ. A chamber orchestra mainly consists of strings, with limited wind or brass instruments occasionally added.

SEE ALSO

◀ 170–171 Orchestral forms

◀ 174–175 Strings

◀ 176–177 Woodwind

◀ 178–179 Brass

◀ 182–183 Percussion

The conductor 186–187 ▶

What is the score? 194–195 ▶

Classical music 204–207 ▶

▽ Seating plan

Strings sit at the front of the orchestra, nearest to the conductor. Woodwind sit as a group in the center of the orchestra, with brass, percussion, and harps ranged around the back of the orchestra.

